DOSSIER · 16 OCTOBER 2026

TESLA ROADSTER

“Turns out the future does have flying cars.” Everything about the unveiling of the new Roadster with SpaceX cold-gas thrusters: variants, specs, prices, timeline, comparison with earlier generations, FSD, reactions and criticism.



0.81 s
0–60 mph in the demo

>370 km/h
top speed (claim)

>480 km
range (target)

2028
planned production start

Compiled for Willem Vroom · Verified facts with sources only; Musk-only claims and unconfirmed information are labelled.
Cover photo: Tesla, @Tesla on X.

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15 Oct
Unveiled at SpaceX test site McGregor (Texas), 7:55 pm local = 16 Oct 02:55 Amsterdam time

3
Trims: Performance, Thrust and Rocket (flying, invite-only)

€50,000
Reservation amount Performance in NL (€5,000 + €45,000)

No
official price, battery capacity or weight announced

Almost nine years after its surprise debut in 2017, Tesla unveiled the new Roadster in the night of 15 to 16 October 2026 (Amsterdam time). Developed together with SpaceX, it is a two-seater with a fan suction system that lets it cling to a track upside down, plus cold-gas thrusters with which a prototype jumped, did a “kickflip” over the Semi and other Teslas, and landed softly.[1,2,5]

Musk posted a 15-second video at 03:57 Amsterdam time captioned *“Turns out the future does have flying cars”*; at the time of writing it had more than 24.6 million views and about 478,000 likes. Willem quoted it with “SpaceX roadster” — which fits: according to Tesla and Musk, the car is the result of Tesla and SpaceX engineers working closely together.[3,3,5]

Labels used in this dossier

OFFICIAL TESLA published by Tesla MUSK ONLY Musk statement/promise without independent confirmation PER MEDIA reported by media, not by Tesla ESTIMATE third-party estimate UNCONFIRMED unconfirmed / conflicting

Important: all performance figures are Tesla claims, measured by Tesla on a prototype. There are no independent tests yet.

02 THE UNVEIL



The prototype drives up a towering curved ramp, hangs upside down and jumps off. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X), "Holy smokes".

The event took place at SpaceX's test site in McGregor near Waco (Texas), was livestreamed on X and, per The Verge, lasted under 30 minutes. On stage: Elon Musk, design chief Franz von Holzhausen and Lars Moravy (VP vehicle engineering). An earlier date (1 October) was postponed due to severe weather.[4,2,43]

What was demonstrated

- **Driving upside down** – a fan suction system under the car (Tesla: up to 2 g) kept the prototype stuck to a vertical/inverted track. OFFICIAL TESLA [1,2]
- **Flight & barrel roll** – from the top the car flew forward on SpaceX-supplied cold-gas thrusters (>80 kN per the presentation), rolled and landed slowly in a white cloud.[1]
- **"Kickflip" over the line-up** – jumped with a twist over Model 3, Model Y, Cybertruck, Semi and Cybercab.[2,3]
- **0–60 mph** – first run ~1.0 s; live run 0.81 s; Tesla later posted 0.67 s "with rollout subtracted". OFFICIAL TESLA [37,38,1]



Jump with a twist over the Semi and other Teslas. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).



Controlled descent on cold-gas thrusters. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).

> "It can basically fly like a rocket. It can do, like, crazy gymnastics... This is not necessarily a safety-optimized car, but it takes the fun meter to 11 out of 10."
>
> Elon Musk at the event[1,2]

Caveats about the demo

- The stunts were not human-driven: per Engadget an Optimus robot sat in the driver's seat “for show” and the car was programmed; Electrek writes nobody was in the car.[7,9]
- The flying car was a different prototype from the stage car (different wheels).[1]
- Based on underbody frames, Electrek speculates the stunt prototype may have lacked a (full) battery. UNCONFIRMED [9]
- The 0–60 times were measured by Tesla itself; method and conditions are not independently verified.[9]

03 VARIANTS & SPECIFICATIONS

Since 2017 six (second-generation) Roadster variants have been announced: three in 2017/2018 and three at the 2026 unveil. None has been delivered so far.

The three official configurations (2026) OFFICIAL TESLA

	Performance	Thrust	Rocket
Character	Road ready	Race ready	Air ready
Seats	2	2	1
Systems	Active aerodynamics + multi-mode suction system	Suction system + rear-mounted cold-gas thrusters	Suction + perimeter-mounted thrusters: forward, upward and lateral rotation – "So...yes, it can fly"
0–60 mph	< 1.6 s	< 0.9 s	< 0.59 s
0–97 km/h (conversion)	< 1.6 s	< 0.9 s	< 0.59 s
Top speed	not stated	not stated	> 230 mph (≈ > 370 km/h, conversion)
Range	> 300 miles (≈ > 483 km, conversion)		
Reserve	Tesla.com/Roadster		

Source: the "Configurations" post by @Tesla on X[36,11]. 0–100 km/h was not given by Tesla; 0–60 mph = 0–97 km/h.

How Tesla.com/roadster (NL) presents it (16-10-2026) OFFICIAL TESLA

Performance is the base ("Reserve"). **Thrust** and **Rocket** are "Augments": Thrust = "Limited edition", includes Performance aero + Multi-Mode Suction + acceleration thrusters; Rocket = "Invite only", 1 seat, includes Performance and Thrust plus a full-flight system. Reservation: **€5,000 due today** (free cancellation) and **€45,000 within 10 days**; the reservation is final only after payment and is cancelled if not paid within 10 days; no refunds for changes.[10,12]

This confirms Thrust/Rocket are add-ons on top of Performance. Source: Tesla NL site (Willem's screenshot, 16-10-2026).

All announced variants (incl. 2017/2018)

Variant	Key specs	Price / deposit	Availability / status
Base (2017 concept) ANNOUNCED, NEVER DELIVERED	0–60 mph 1.9 s; >250 mph; 620 mi; 200 kWh; 3 motors; 4 seats; glass roof[21,19]	$200,000; reservation $50,000[21]	Delivery promised for 2020; never built. Superseded by the 2026 design.[23]
Founders Series (2017) ANNOUNCED, NEVER DELIVERED	Same specs as Base per Tesla (2017)[21]	$250,000, paid in full upfront[20,21]	1,000 reservations; never delivered. How they map onto the 2026 variants has not been publicly explained. UNCONFIRMED [3,4]

Variant	Key specs	Price / deposit	Availability / status
"SpaceX option package" (2018) MUSK ONLY	~10 small cold-gas thrusters around the car; COPV tank replacing rear seats; ~10,000 psi; 0–60 mph around 1 s[23,3]	Never priced	Only via Musk tweets/podcasts. Appears to have evolved into Thrust/Rocket in 2026 (our interpretation). UNCONFIRMED
Performance (2026) OFFICIAL TESLA	2 seats; active aero + multi-mode suction; no thrusters; 0–60 < 1.6 s; >300 mi (target)[11,2]	Price unknown; deposit $50,000 / €50,000[12,5]	"Road ready", by reservation; reservable in NL. Production 2028.[10,1]
Thrust (2026) OFFICIAL TESLA	2 seats; suction + rear cold-gas thrusters; 0–60 < 0.9 s (demo 0.81 s)[11,2,37]	Price unknown; deposit $250,000 / €250,000 (NL: €5,000 + €245,000) OFFICIAL TESLA [5,10]	"Race ready", limited release; road approval not stated.[11,9]
Rocket (2026) OFFICIAL TESLA	1 seat; suction + 10 thrusters all round ("full flight system"); 0–60 < 0.59 s; >230 mph[2,3]	Unknown	Invite only; "not approved for public road use"; not in all regions.[10]

No 2026 "Founders Series" or "Signature" edition has been announced. Notably, a footnote on Tesla's page says the specifications shown reflect the "Thrust augment only", "available as an optional upgrade" – so Thrust may be an upgrade on Performance rather than a separate model. UNCONFIRMED [11,10]

Detailed 2026 specifications

Item	Value (all trims unless stated)
Demo acceleration	0–60 mph 0.81 s; 0.67 s without rollout OFFICIAL TESLA [37,38] NL site for Thrust: "0–100 in under 1 second"[10]
Top speed	> 230 mph (> 370 km/h) OFFICIAL TESLA – The Verge/Autoblog: Rocket; TechCrunch: all trims UNCONFIRMED Musk wants to "crack halfway to the speed of sound" (Mach 0.5 ≈ 380 mph) MUSK ONLY [5,3]
Range	> 300 miles (> 480 km); target, not an EPA/WLTP rating OFFICIAL TESLA [2,3,5]
Battery / power	Not disclosed (the 2017 concept's 200 kWh does not apply) UNCONFIRMED
Weight	Not disclosed; Marques Brownlee mentioned "4000+ pound" – not official UNCONFIRMED [3]
Thrusters & gas	>80 kN; two ultra-high-pressure air tanks totalling 600 litres with ~250 kg of air; 10 nozzles; self-recharging, no chemical propellant; COPVs in "every usable void"; 4–5× the force tyres can transmit OFFICIAL TESLA [1,2,39,40]
Suction system	Up to 2 g; holds the car upside down even when stationary. Electrek saw 4,700 kg downforce on screen and finds it doubtful. OFFICIAL TESLA UNCONFIRMED [10,9]
Controls & interior	Steer-by-wire yoke; manual controls; fixed seat; centre screen + two small displays; magnesium, titanium, carbon fibre; butterfly doors OFFICIAL TESLA [10,2,1]
Production	Start 2028 ("actually", Musk said with a laugh); Giga Texas cited by media MUSK ONLY PER MEDIA [1,18]

Conversions: 60 mph ≈ 97 km/h; 230 mph ≈ 370 km/h; 300 miles ≈ 483 km.

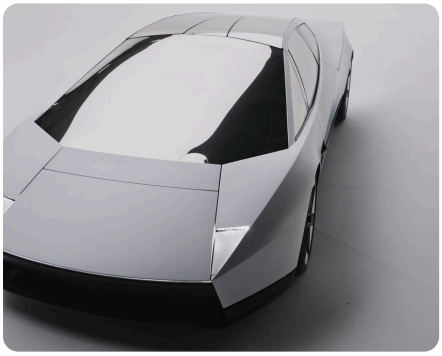
04 DESIGN & ENGINEERING



Butterfly doors, hidden headlights and a full-width light bar. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X), "Configurations".

Tesla says the design is inspired by the SR-71 Blackbird and F-35, and that its design language has evolved "from S3XY to Cybertruck, Cybercab & Optimus". Car and Driver sees a resemblance to the white Lotus Esprit S1 from the Bond film *The Spy Who Loved Me* – a car Musk owns, which was on display at the event.[4][1,1,3]

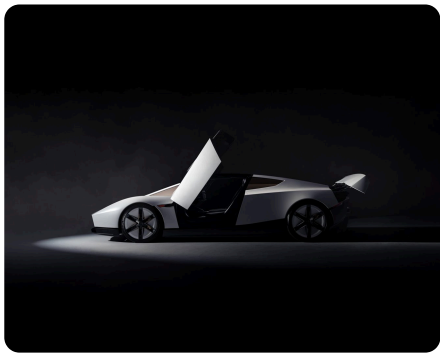
Ano White paint is, per Tesla, derived from aerospace coatings (UV and cryogenic protection, electrostatic dissipation); the **gold-tinted glass** mimics spacesuit visors. The **active rear wing** has high-drag and high-downforce modes and is driven by the Optimus actuator system. In **Track Mode** the car lowers and the suspension transforms. OFFICIAL TESLA [10,1,4,2]



New angular design language. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).



Super-light thin-spoke wheels. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).



Side view, doors open. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).



Ultrawhite interior with grey microsuede. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).



Yoke for steer-by-wire and centre screen. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).



COPV pressure vessel for the cold gas. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).



Four rear thruster nozzles. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).



Suspension and chassis. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).

How does it work, in short?
Suction system ("fan car"): fans create low pressure under the car, sealed by adjustable skirts, adding grip without adding mass. **Cold-gas thrusters**: compressed air from tanks is expelled through nozzles; the car refills the tanks itself with a compressor (refill time and energy use not disclosed). Per Electrek, rear thrusters aid acceleration and lateral ones might help in corners, but upward thrust adds no driving performance – it is mostly show.[9,2]

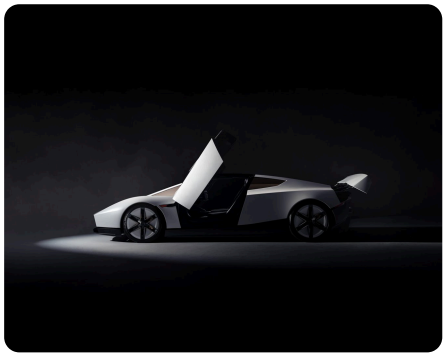
Interior, body & seating

Item	What is known
Seating	2 seats (Performance, Thrust); 1 seat (Rocket). The 2017 concept was a 2+2. OFFICIAL TESLA [11,2,23]
Seats	"Fixed seat"; per The Verge the seats are molded directly into the chassis. No seat adjustment – unknown whether yoke/pedals adjust. OFFICIAL TESLA [11,2]
Chassis / monocoque	Willem's point "seats fixed into the monocoque" is right about seats being fixed into the chassis. Whether the chassis is a (carbon) **monocoque** has not been stated by Tesla – **unconfirmed**. Tesla only cites magnesium, titanium and carbon fibre "throughout". UNCONFIRMED [11,2]
Upholstery & interior colours	Ultrawhite interior with grey microsuede accents and microsuede bolsters. No other interior colours announced. OFFICIAL TESLA [11]
Screens & steering	Centre touchscreen + two smaller forward displays; yoke designed for steer-by-wire. OFFICIAL TESLA [11]
Exterior colours	Shown: Ano White (derived from rocket coatings) with gold-tinted glass. Other colours not disclosed. OFFICIAL TESLA UNCONFIRMED [10,23]
Doors	Upward-opening **butterfly doors** per coverage; Tesla names no type on its product page. PER MEDIA [1]
Roof	The 2017 concept had a removable glass roof (targa). For the 2026 car a removable roof is **not mentioned** – unknown. UNCONFIRMED [23]
Luggage space	Trunk and frunk volume (litres) **not disclosed**; not known whether there is a frunk. Where a removable roof would be stowed: unknown (not described by Tesla, not even for the 2017 concept). UNCONFIRMED [11,75]

Item	What is known
Luggage without thrusters?	Tesla says the COPV pressure vessels sit in “every usable void”; per Car and Driver there are two tanks totalling 600 litres. In 2018 Musk said the tank would replace the rear seats. Performance has no thrusters and so presumably no tanks – but Tesla has **not said** whether that space becomes luggage room or a frunk on Performance. Per-variant difference: **unknown**. UNCONFIRMED [39,1,23]
Tank location & rear section	MotorTrend saw on the displayed car one large black COPV sphere (exercise-ball size) **directly behind the two seats**, connected by two pipes to the four nozzles above the rear bumper. This supports Willem’s observation that the tank sits behind the cockpit/“monocoque”. Note: Tesla and The Verge speak of *two* tanks (600 L combined). That the whole rear section hinges upward as one clamshell: **observed in the unveil video (Willem’s observation), not officially confirmed**. PER MEDIA UNCONFIRMED [80,2]



Interior: Ultrawhite and microsuede. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X), interior photos.



Doors open. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X), exterior photos.



Top view: roof/glass. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).

05 TECHNICAL DEEP-DIVE

Short answer: Tesla disclosed almost no powertrain or battery data at the unveil. Only the range target (>300 miles), the by-wire controls and the thruster/suction system are confirmed. Everything else is unknown or from unofficial sources.[11,4,75]

Topic	Performance	Thrust	Rocket
Range	>300 miles (>480 km) as a *target* for Performance; no EPA or WLTP rating. Thrust/Rocket: not specified. OFFICIAL TESLA [11,2]		
Battery (kWh, chemistry, cells)	Not disclosed by Tesla. PASMAG reports 200 kWh with 4680 cylindrical cells – that is the 2017 figure and is not on Tesla's page. UNCONFIRMED [74,75]		
Power (kW / hp)	Not disclosed. UNCONFIRMED [75,4]		
Motors / drivetrain	Number and position of motors not disclosed; AWD not confirmed. **No RWD variant has been announced.** For comparison, the 2017 concept officially had 3 motors (1 front, 2 rear), all-wheel drive and torque vectoring. Whether the 2026 car keeps that ("tri-motor/Plaid") is unknown. UNCONFIRMED [23,21,75]		
Extra propulsion	No thrusters; suction + active aero OFFICIAL TESLA	Rear cold-gas thrusters OFFICIAL TESLA	Thrusters all round (forward, up, rotation) OFFICIAL TESLA
Charging (kW, connector, 10–80%)	Not disclosed. PASMAG cites "350 kW or more" and 15–20 min for "significant range" – not confirmed on Tesla's page. EU connector not stated (all current EU Teslas use CCS2 – an assumption, not confirmed for Roadster). UNCONFIRMED [74,75]		
Thruster tank refill	–	On-board compressor refills tanks from the traction battery; no chemical propellant. Refill time/energy unknown. OFFICIAL TESLA [1,74]	
Electrical architecture	Not disclosed (no info on 400 V/800 V, 48 V low-voltage or an Ethernet ring). For comparison, Cybertruck officially has a 48 V "mid-voltage" system, an HV battery of 700 V DC nominal and an "Etherloop" network. UNCONFIRMED [75,76,77,78]		
Steer-by-wire	**Yes** – "next-gen steer-by-wire" with yoke. OFFICIAL TESLA [11,2]		
Brake-by-wire / throttle-by-wire	The Verge: steering, brakes and throttle are "by wire". Tesla's own page only mentions steer-by-wire; brake implementation details (e.g. no hydraulic back-up) are unknown. PER MEDIA [2,11]		
Rear-wheel steering	**Not mentioned** – unknown whether Roadster has rear-wheel steering; no angle disclosed. UNCONFIRMED [11]		

Comparison with Cybertruck (official)

System	Cybertruck	Roadster 2026
Steer-by-wire	Yes: "4-wheel directional steer-by-wire", 0.94 turns lock-to-lock (340°)[76]	Yes, yoke OFFICIAL TESLA [11]
Rear-wheel steering	Yes ("rear steering"); maximum angle not stated in the Tesla documents consulted[79,76]	Unknown UNCONFIRMED

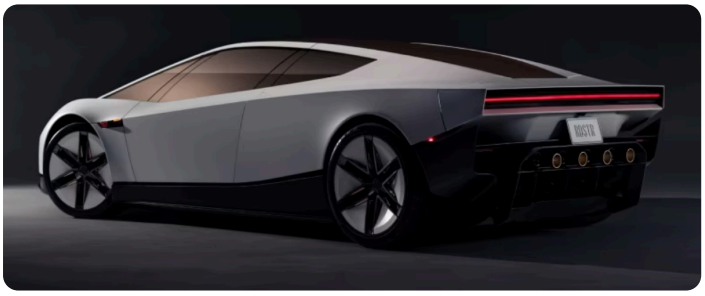
System	Cybertruck	Roadster 2026
Brakes	ABS + EBD; wiring shows iBooster ECU and hydraulic unit (HCU/ESP) – so not fully dry brake-by-wire[76,78]	“By wire” per The Verge; details unknown PER MEDIA
Accelerator	Electronic accelerator (as in all EVs)[76]	“By wire” per The Verge PER MEDIA
Voltage levels	48 V MV system; HV 700 V DC nominal; Etherloop[76,77,78]	Unknown UNCONFIRMED

06 PRICES & RESERVATIONS

Key point
Tesla has announced **no purchase price** for the new Roadster – neither in the US nor in the Netherlands. Only reservation amounts are known.[4,23]

Official amounts

What	US	Netherlands	Status
Reservation Performance (post-unveil)	$50.000[5,23]	€5,000 today (free cancellation) + €45,000 within 10 days = €50,000; lapses without timely payment[10,12]	OFFICIAL TESLA
Reservation Thrust	$250.000[5,23]	€5,000 today (free cancellation) + €245,000 within 10 days = €250,000; limited availability, max. one order per customer[10,12]	OFFICIAL TESLA
Rocket	Invite only; no amount[10,23]		OFFICIAL TESLA
Reservation before the unveil (Sep 2026)	–	€4,000 + €39,000 = €43,000; cancellable free of charge[15,14]	PER MEDIA
Purchase price 2026 trims	Not known		UNCONFIRMED



Rear view with the four thruster nozzles above the bumper, as shown on tesla.com/roadster (NL). Photo: Tesla, via tesla.com/roadster.

Thrust terms (Tesla NL) OFFICIAL TESLA

Due to limited availability only one Thrust order per customer is allowed; duplicate orders via the same account, phone number, payment or address details may be cancelled. Availability depends on legal requirements per region. Reservation final only after payment; cancelled if not paid within 10 days; no refunds for changes.[10,12]

Source: tesla.com/roadster (NL), Willem's screenshots 16-10-2026 13:40.

Estimates and rumours

Before the unveil Autoblog.nl reported rumours that a "SpaceX Package" version could cost "more than 1 million euros" – a rumour, not a substantiated estimate. The $250,000 Thrust deposit implies that trim will cost at least that much (our inference). ESTIMATE [14]

Price history across generations

Generation	Price	Deposit
1st generation (2008–2012)	approx. $100,000 (US) PER MEDIA [22]	up to $50,000 (US); €3,000 in Europe (2010)[22]

Generation	Price	Deposit
2nd-gen concept (2017)	from $200,000; Founders $250,000[21,19]	$50,000 (first $5,000 immediately); Founders in full[23,21]
New Roadster (2026)	Not known UNCONFIRMED	$50,000 Performance / $250,000 Thrust[5]

Production and sales volumes

Topic	What is known
2017 plan	Production from 2020 with 10,000 units ANNOUNCED, NEVER DELIVERED[23]
Founders Series (2017)	First 1,000 units[21,23]
2026 Roadster volume per year	Not disclosed by Tesla. Thrust: “limited release”; Rocket: “invite only”. A secondary source cites “fewer than 10,000 per year” – unconfirmed. UNCONFIRMED[2,81]
Reservation count	Never disclosed UNCONFIRMED
Factory	Giga Texas (Austin): named by Musk for Roadster in 2022; media also cite Giga Texas in 2026. No official production-line details. MUSK ONLY PER MEDIA[23,18]
Analysts	CNBC: high-end, low-volume model, no material financial impact expected. No concrete analyst volume estimates found. ESTIMATE[4]

Taxes and a worked example follow in the next chapter.

07 DUTCH TAXES

What would a Roadster cost in Dutch BPM, road tax and (company-car) bijtelling? Because Tesla has not disclosed price or weight and production only starts in 2028, the amounts below are **worked examples** based on 2026 rules and adopted policy for later years. ESTIMATE

1. BPM

For a zero-emission passenger car (0 g/km CO_2) the 2026 BPM is a **fixed €687**, regardless of price. The amount is indexed annually; the 2027/2028 rate has not been published. For the Roadster this means BPM is negligible relative to the price – even for a very expensive Thrust. OFFICIAL SOURCE [32,73]

2. Motor vehicle tax (road tax)

MRB depends on weight, fuel and province. A fully electric passenger car pays a percentage of the petrol rate (national part and provincial surcharge). Since 1 July 2026 the *mass in running order* counts.[67,66,68]

Year	EV discount	You pay
2026–2028	30%	70% of the rate
2029	25%	75%
from 2030	0%	100%

OFFICIAL SOURCE Source: Rijksoverheid[65,66]. A Roadster registered in 2028 thus gets 30% for one year, then 25%, and full rate from 2030.

Worked example ESTIMATE – Tesla has not disclosed weight. Marques Brownlee mentioned “4000+ pound” (≈ 1,815 kg, unofficial); so we use an *assumed* mass in running order of 1,900 and 2,000 kg. Amounts per quarter, 2026 rates (later years are indexed).[3]

Weight · province	Petrol rate	EV 2026–28 (70%)	EV 2029 (75%)	EV per year (70%)
1,900 kg · Noord-Holland (82.1 opc.)	€ 333.99	€ 233.80	€ 250.50	€ 935
1,900 kg · Utrecht (86.4 opc.)	€ 339.98	€ 237.99	€ 254.99	€ 952
1,900 kg · Gelderland (98.3 opc.)	€ 356.55	€ 249.59	€ 267.41	€ 998
1,900 kg · Zuid-Holland (104.4 opc.)	€ 365.05	€ 255.53	€ 273.79	€ 1,022
2,000 kg · Noord-Holland (82.1 opc.)	€ 360.85	€ 252.60	€ 270.64	€ 1,010
2,000 kg · Utrecht (86.4 opc.)	€ 367.34	€ 257.14	€ 275.51	€ 1,029
2,000 kg · Gelderland (98.3 opc.)	€ 385.30	€ 269.71	€ 288.98	€ 1,079
2,000 kg · Zuid-Holland (104.4 opc.)	€ 394.51	€ 276.16	€ 295.88	€ 1,105

Calculation: petrol national part (Art. 23 MRB Act 1994: €64.24 at 1,000 kg + €17.27 per 100 kg) + provincial surcharge on the Art. 222 Provinces Act base (€45.81 at 1,100 kg + €11.68 per 100 kg) × 2026 surcharge rate. The Belastingdienst calculator is authoritative; rounding per weight class may differ by a few euros.[69,70,68]

3. Bijtelling (company car only)

If you drive a Roadster as a company car (>500 km private use per year), a percentage of the list price is added to your income. First registration 2026: 18% on the first €30,000 and 22% above. Under adopted policy this becomes 20%/22% in 2027 and 22% on the full value from 2028. The rate is fixed for 60 months. Because Roadster arrives in 2028 at the earliest, **22% on the full list price** is expected to apply.[71,72]

List price (HYPOTHETICAL)	BPM (2026 amount)	Bijtelling/yr if reg. 2026	DET 2027	DET 2028
Performance – hypothetical: € 200,000	€ 687	€ 42,800	€ 43,400	€ 44,000
Thrust – hypothetical: € 350,000	€ 687	€ 75,800	€ 76,400	€ 77,000
Rocket	Not approved for public roads → no registration, so no BPM/MRB/bijtelling as a passenger car.[10]			

Note

The list prices of €200,000 and €350,000 are **hypothetical** and only illustrate the calculation; they are not price expectations from Tesla or from us. Bijtelling is added to gross income; net cost depends on your tax bracket. VAT (21%) is included in the list price. ESTIMATE

08 EU TYPE APPROVAL

Can the Roadster be driven on Dutch roads? That requires European (or national) approval. Tesla has said nothing yet about EU homologation or an EU delivery date.[61,62]

Facts

• New cars in the EU must be approved in advance under Regulation (EU) 2018/858. Routes: EU whole-vehicle type approval (WVTA), EU small series (max. 1,500 passenger cars per year), national small series, or individual approval. OFFICIAL SOURCE [60,57,58]
• A manufacturer chooses which EU approval authority to apply to; the approval then applies EU-wide. In April 2026 the RDW was the first in Europe to approve Tesla's FSD Supervised (provisionally valid in NL).[58,27,29]
• For technology the rules don't cover, there is the Art. 39 procedure (new technology, with an EU vote); the RDW explained it in 2025 in response to Tesla.[59]
• Precedent: the Cybertruck has no EU type approval (parliamentary questions).[63]
• Tesla NL itself says Rocket is "not approved for public road use" and not available in all regions. Reservations are open in NL; Performance is called "road ready". OFFICIAL TESLA [10,12]

Expectations and possible hurdles ESTIMATE

• **Which authority?** The RDW is an obvious candidate given Tesla's European HQ in NL and the FSD approval, but this is **unconfirmed** for the Roadster. UNCONFIRMED
• **Cold-gas thrusters**: there are no specific EU rules for thrusters on a car; high-pressure tanks (~250 kg of air) and exhaust near bystanders are open questions. French media expect mainly Performance to have a chance at road approval; Thrust/Rocket possibly track/private land only. "Flying" would bring aviation law into play.[61,62,9]
• **Pedestrian protection & safety systems**: the sharp, angular design and mandatory EU assistance systems (General Safety Regulation) must be accommodated – as with Cybertruck, which still lacks EU approval.[61,63]
• **Steer-by-wire & noise**: steer-by-wire must meet UN/ECE steering rules; the powerful suction fans may matter for noise limits. Tesla has said nothing about this.[61] UNCONFIRMED

> **What does this mean for Dutch buyers?**
> You can reserve now (Performance €50,000, cancellable free of charge per Tesla), but there is no guarantee or date for EU approval. Production only starts in 2028; European deliveries realistically won't come earlier. How EU consumer law treats such large deposits is untested.[12,15,64]

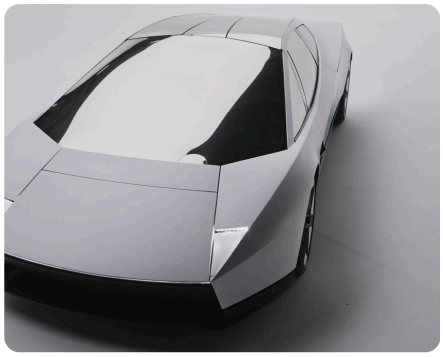
09 THREE GENERATIONS COMPARED



1st generation (2008–2012). Photo: Tesla Motors, Wikimedia Commons.



2nd-gen concept (2017). Photo: Steve Jurvetson, CC BY 2.0, Wikimedia Commons.



New Roadster (2026). Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).

	1st generation	2nd-gen concept 2017	New Roadster 2026
0–60 mph	3,9 s (Sport 3,7 s)[22]	1,9 s ANNOUNCED, NEVER DELIVERED [21]	<1.6 s (Performance); demo 0.81 s OFFICIAL TESLA [11,37]
Top speed	201 km/h (125 mph)[22]	>400 km/h (>250 mph) ANNOUNCED, NEVER DELIVERED [21]	>370 km/h (>230 mph) OFFICIAL TESLA [2]
Range	393 km (244 mi, EPA)[22]	1.000 km (620 mi) ANNOUNCED, NEVER DELIVERED [21]	>480 km (target) OFFICIAL TESLA [2]
Battery	53 kWh[22]	200 kWh ANNOUNCED, NEVER DELIVERED [21]	Unknown UNCONFIRMED
Drivetrain	1 motor, rear-wheel[22]	3 motors, AWD ANNOUNCED, NEVER DELIVERED [23]	Unknown UNCONFIRMED
Seats	2	2+2	2 (Rocket: 1)
Price	approx. $100,000 PER MEDIA [22]	$200.000 / Founders $250.000[21]	Unknown; deposit $50k/$250k[5]
Production	2008–2012, approx. 2,450 units[22]	Never built	From 2028 (Musk) MUSK ONLY [1]
Notable	Lotus Elise-based; first series EV with Li-ion cells; one was launched into space in 2018 (Falcon Heavy)[22,55]	Removable glass roof; later "SpaceX option package" promised[23]	Suction system, cold-gas thrusters, steer-by-wire, fixed seats[11]

The difference in short: the first Roadster proved an electric sports car could exist (converted Lotus, one motor). The 2017 concept promised a record-breaking 2+2 GT with 200 kWh and 1,000 km – and was never built. The 2026 version is a radically different, lighter two-seat (or one-seat) design in which suction and SpaceX thrusters, not the battery, take centre stage; the ambitious 2017 range has given way to ">300 miles".



Musk's own 1st-gen Roadster with "Starman", launched 6 Feb 2018.
Photo: SpaceX, CC0, Wikimedia Commons.

10 TIMELINE

2008–2012
1st generation: approx. 2,450 Roadsters delivered.[22]

16-11-2017
Surprise 2nd-gen reveal after the Semi event; delivery promised for 2020, $200,000.[23]

06-02-2018
Musk's own Roadster is launched on Falcon Heavy.[55]

06-2018
Musk: "SpaceX option package" with ~10 cold-gas thrusters.[23]

2020–2021
Production pushed to 2021, then 2022, then 2023.[23]

2023–2024
Target slips to 2024, then 2025.[23]

11-2025
Musk: unveil 1 April 2026, production 12–18 months later.[23]

22-04-2026
Musk on the Roadster as a car to drive yourself (Q1 call).[24]

12-09-2026
Tesla: "Go for launch" – event announced for 1 October.[46]

19-09-2026
NL reservations reopened: €43,000.[14]

28-09-2026
Event postponed to 15 October (weather).[43]

15/16-10-2026
Unveil in McGregor; three trims; production 2028. Musk: "Turns out the future does have flying cars".[1]

2028
Planned production start.[5]

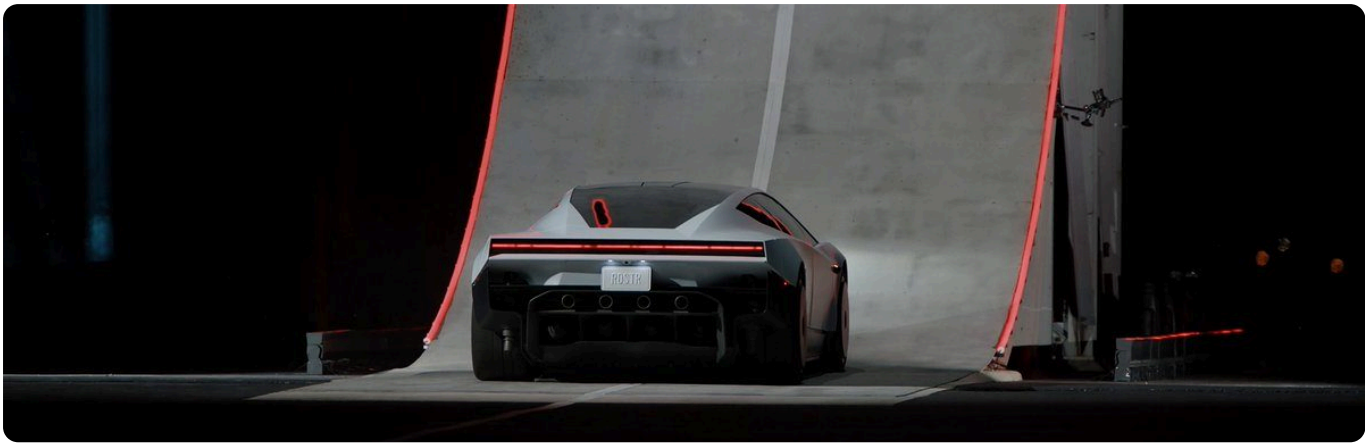
11 FSD & SELF-DRIVING

Does Roadster get FSD? Tesla has **not announced** it. Musk positions the Roadster as a car you drive yourself – “the last best driver’s car”.[2,26]

• On the Q1 call (22-04-2026) Musk described Roadster as a car about driving yourself, in a future where other Teslas become autonomous; media summarised it as “the only Tesla you actually drive”. MUSK ONLY [24,25,26]
• Tesla’s product page mentions no Autopilot, FSD or FSD computer (HW4/AI5); it does mention manual controls and a fixed seat. UNCONFIRMED [10,11]
• The stunts were performed by the car itself (programmed), with an Optimus “for show” at the wheel – which says nothing about FSD in the production car.[7]

FSD status in NL/EU
On 10 April 2026 the RDW approved FSD Supervised as a European type approval with provisional validity in the Netherlands – a European first. EU-wide recognition requires a vote in the Brussels committee (TCMV); at the 6 October 2026 meeting no vote took place.[27,28,29,30,31]

12 REACTIONS & CRITICISM



Prototype on the ramp. Photo: Tesla (official press image via @Tesla on X).

> “Candidate for greatest product demo of all time”
>
> @elonmusk beforehand[45]

> “My OG Roadster is still orbiting Mars and Earth”
>
> @elonmusk, 16-10-2026[47]

Critical notes

- **Nearly a decade of delays**: Tesla missed every earlier delivery date; $50,000 deposits (and $250,000 for Founders) have been held since 2017. Autoblog.nl says many waiting customers cancelled in disappointment.[4,14]
- **Show vs. product**: Electrek asks whether the claims are “full of cold gas”: upward thrust doesn’t help driving, 4,700 kg downforce is doubtful, and the stunt prototype may have lacked a full battery.[9]
- **No driver**: the stunts were programmed; an Optimus sat in “for show”.[7]
- **Financially small**: CNBC expects no material impact on Tesla’s results.[4]
- **Missing specs**: no price, battery, power or weight.[4,75]
- **Safety**: Musk himself: “not necessarily a safety-optimized car”.[1,2]

13 VIDEOS

All links checked on 16-10-2026 (YouTube oEmbed: HTTP 200). Click title or URL.



Livestream replay of the Roadster event
@Tesla · X OFFICIAL TESLA
https://x.com/i/broadcasts/1yKAPwNggRaxb



“Turns out the future does have flying cars”
@elonmusk · X · 15 s
https://x.com/elonmusk/status/2110913107094606330



Roadster Event
Tesla · YouTube OFFICIAL TESLA
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qt5p-_tE8d0



Roadster | The Last Best Driver's Car
Tesla · YouTube OFFICIAL TESLA
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cvKIR-c1SsU



The Ramp | Roadster
Tesla · YouTube OFFICIAL TESLA
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7p5LxFdc-Qg



The Kickflip | Roadster
Tesla · YouTube OFFICIAL TESLA
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r5vsHHPVhJg



Tesla's Flying Roadster Revealed: Everything That Happened in 10 Minutes
CNET · YouTube
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TWHXrLzUKJc



I Went To The Tesla Roadster Unveil! Insane Stunts, Battery & Motor, Interior, Design
Out of Spec Reviews · YouTube
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7oFL2ObpM08



INSIDE LOOK! I saw the Flying Tesla Roadster in Person and it was CRAZY
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https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_lq-DpCE9rU



Tesla Unveils 'Flying' Roadster with SpaceX Thrusters
VideoFromSpace · YouTube
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eqOfmtTJD1A



Tesla Semi & Roadster Unveil (2017)
Tesla · YouTube OFFICIAL TESLA
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5RRmepp7i5g

14 UNCLEAR & UNVERIFIABLE

- Purchase price of all trims (US and NL).
- Battery capacity, cell type, power, motors/drivetrain (AWD/RWD), charging speed, voltage architecture, weight.
- Whether >230 mph applies to all trims or only Rocket (sources conflict).
- Whether Thrust is a separate trim or an optional “augment” on Performance (Tesla footnote).
- What happens to the 2017 reservations and Founders Series.
- One or two pressure vessels; whether the rear opens as a clamshell; luggage per trim; removable roof.
- Rear-wheel steering and brake-by-wire implementation.
- EU type approval: authority, route and date; road legality of Thrust.
- Whether the demo car had a full battery; independent measurement of 0–60 and downforce.
- 2028 production start is a Musk statement; earlier dates were all missed.

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